MERROWFIELD DIGITAL

Playbook: Denial of service

Document Playbook 08 | Rev 3 | Effective 9 February 2026 | Owner: Security Operations | Review cycle: 12 months

1. What this playbook covers

This playbook covers attacks that make a customer-facing service unavailable or slow by flooding it with traffic. It is used by the Security Analyst who investigates, from the first alert until the incident is closed.

2. How it is usually recognised

- a sudden traffic spike or a saturated load balancer
- a content delivery network alert
- error rates rising on the website, the app or the login service
- customers reporting that they cannot reach the site

3. The first hour

1. Enable scrubbing with the content delivery network or network provider.
2. Deploy rate limits and bot rules on the targeted endpoints.
3. Scale out where the service allows it.
4. Apply geographic filtering only as a temporary measure.
5. Update the status page, and open a provider ticket for upstream filtering.

4. Evidence to preserve

- traffic captures and the provider's attack report
- the times the outage started and ended on each customer-facing service
- error-rate and order-volume graphs for the attack window

5. Establishing the facts a report needs

Whatever is decided, the decision needs these facts, established as early as they can be:

- exactly how long each customer-facing service was unavailable
- how many customers were affected, estimated from traffic
- the direct financial loss: lost orders and emergency capacity
- whether there was any intrusion alongside the flood - usually there is none

6. Reporting

Which reporting procedures apply is settled from the incident's facts by the rules in Plan 01, section 8, and each procedure's deadlines are read from that procedure. This playbook sets no deadline of its own, and the decision belongs to the Data Protection Officer.

An outage of a customer-facing service lasting more than 60 minutes makes the incident significant under Procedure 02, even though no personal data is involved.

7. What affected customers should do

When customers are told, the notice gives them these steps, in this order:

- No action is needed: a flood of traffic takes no data.
- If a payment seemed to fail during the outage, check your order history before trying again, so you are not charged twice.
- Merrowfield will never ask you to enter your card details again by email.

8. Closing the incident

Keep the rate limits as defaults, review capacity against the attack's peak, and agree faster escalation with the provider.